COVID-19 Cases, Deaths, and Hospitalizations in Persons Who Are Not Fully Vaccinated

Washington State Department of Health

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COVID-19 vaccines are effective and critical tools to aid in the control of the COVID-19 pandemic. This brief provides an overview of confirmed or probable COVID-19 cases, hospitalizations, and deaths among persons who are not fully vaccinated in Washington state.

People who are **not** fully vaccinated include those who have not received any dose of a COVID-19 vaccine or have received one or more doses of a COVID-19 vaccine but are not yet fully protected. Full protection from vaccination occurs about 2 weeks after receiving the final dose of an authorized COVID-19 vaccine because it typically takes that long for the body to build a high enough level of protection to fight the disease.

Even when a vaccine is highly effective, a small percentage of people who are fully vaccinated will still get COVID-19 if they are exposed to the virus that causes it, this is termed a breakthrough case. These types of cases occur for all vaccine-preventable conditions.

Key findings

- Data between February and June 2021:
  - 97.4% of COVID-19 cases were in those **not** fully vaccinated
  - 96% of hospitalizations among COVID-19 cases were in those **not** fully vaccinated
  - 94.3% of deaths related to COVID-19 were in those **not** fully vaccinated

Context for understanding key findings

- More than 94% of all cases, deaths, and hospitalizations in individuals 12 years or older from Washington state can be attributed to individuals who have **not** been fully vaccinated.
- As of July 24, 2021, 61.4% of those in Washington state who are eligible to receive vaccines have completed an approved vaccination series. As the percent of fully vaccinated people increases, we anticipate that the overall case, hospitalization, and death counts across the state will begin to decline.
- **Getting vaccinated saves lives.** Vaccination prevents severe illness and hospitalization and lowers your risk of dying from COVID-19. It also helps reduce the spread of the virus in communities while supporting communities in remaining open.
- Unvaccinated individuals should get vaccinated and continue masking until they are fully vaccinated. With the emergence of the Delta variant as the dominant strain in Washington and the U.S., it is more urgent than ever to ensure that everyone who can, get vaccinated.
- The nearly 4.4 million fully vaccinated Washingtonians have a very strong degree of protection against COVID-19 variants, including Delta. They are overwhelmingly avoiding severe illness.

Methods

Data sources

There are two data sources for these metrics: the Washington Disease Reporting System (WDRS) and the Washington Immunization Information System (WAIIS). WDRS receives case, hospitalization, and death information for all COVID-19 cases in Washington residents. WAIIS collects COVID-19 vaccination data from healthcare providers for people vaccinated in Washington. Not all federal correction facilities and federal healthcare organizations (e.g., Department of Defense and Veterans Administration facilities) submit data to WAIIS. WAIIS may not include vaccination data from all tribal health facilities. All case, hospitalization, and death data reported are based on positive molecular or antigen test results.

A COVID-19 hospitalization is a Washington resident identified using case investigation data in the Washington Disease Reporting System (WDRS) or linkage with Rapid Health Information Network (RHINO) records as hospitalized with confirmed or probable COVID-19.

Deaths are reported to the state by health care providers, medical examiners or coroners, local health departments, or others to the official vital records database, the Washington Health and Life Events System (WHALES). COVID-19 deaths included in this report are identified in WHALES where the cause of death was confirmed or suspected to have been COVID-19.

Timeframes

The first COVID-19 vaccines were administered in Washington in mid-December 2020. Full protection from the vaccine in those vaccinated early would occur about the first week in February. Therefore, we are reporting cases, deaths, and hospitalizations beginning with in month of February 2021.

It takes up to 8 days from specimen collection date for DOH to receive 90% of reported cases, 12 days for DOH to identify hospitalizations, and 28 days to identify deaths. For this reason, we consider data from the 4 weeks just prior to the report to be incomplete.

Linking methods

All information on COVID-19 cases, deaths, and hospitalizations provided by this report use WDRS data linked to WAIIS COVID vaccination data. The linking is based on a comparison of the first name, last name, and date of birth of cases to the first name, last name, and date of birth of those with COVID-19 vaccination in WAIIS. Only exact matches on all three items are considered the same person. Missing or misspelled names and incorrect dates of birth may lead to some vaccinated persons being incorrectly classified as unvaccinated. Cases with vaccines not reported to WAIIS as described above are also reflected as not fully vaccinated.


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